M18 Hellcat

The M18 Hellcat was one of a series of fast, lightly armored, but powerfully armed US antitank vehicles. It was designed according to the American tank destroyer doctrine formulated before World War II: tanks supported an infantry attack, and if enemy tanks attacked, fast tank destroyers such as the Hellcat would rush to the breakthrough to destroy the enemy tanks, using speed to avoid enemy fire.

THE HELLCAT was designed by Buick and was equipped with the powerful Wright R-975 radial engine. This, combined with its thin armor and open-topped turret (standard on all American tank destroyers), meant it weighed less than 20 tons (18 tonnes) and was very fast, capable of up to 50 mph (80 km/h) on a road. It carried the 76 mm high-velocity gun that was also mounted on the later model Sherman tanks.

REAR VIEW

The Hellcat saw combat service in Europe after D-Day, but struggled to defeat the thicker front armor of later German tanks such as the Panther. High Velocity Armor Piercing (HVAP) ammunition gave a better chance of penetration, but was in short supply. A muzzle brake was added to the gun to help reduce dust from its blast; this was fixed to the last 700 of the 1,857 Hellcats built as tank destroyers. Another 650 unarmed versions, the M39, were made or converted to act as ammunition or troop carriers. Some of these saw service in the Korean War.

SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	M18 Hellcat
Date	1942
Origin	USA
Production	1,857
Engine	Wright Continental R-975 gasoline, 400 hp
Weight	19.6 tons (17.8 tonnes)
Main armament	76 mm M1 or M1A2
Secondary armament	.50 Browning M2 machine gun
Crew	5
Armor thickness	1 in (25 mm) max